Photo Finish

Move over the usual ink-based printers, photo printers are here to take digital photography to a new level

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Inkjet printers have now become standard equipment with PCs: any new PC comes with one. This has mainly been due to the sharp decline in prices. Owners, too, have evolved from using printers primarily for printing text documents, to using them for more creative and image-intensive purposes, such as printing graphs, charts, pictures and decorative banners. This change in usage patterns has been not just because owners need to do more, but also because of advancements in printer technology that facilitate such needs.

Digital photography is taking off in a big way: every other person either has a digicam, or is thinking of getting one. The idea of instant photographs has caught everyone's fancy, too. These printers cater to the segment of users that want to print photos using their home printers. Photo printers are optimised for photo printing, and in fact, text printing on these printers could even be slower than on a regular ink-based printer.

Underneath the skin

Ink-based photo printers differ from regular ink-based printers in a few critical ways. First, they require a greater variety and number of colour cartridges. Most photo printers support light cyan and light magenta in addition to the regular cyan, magenta, yellow and black, making for a total of six separate cartridges. The addition of the light shades means that more subtle variations in colour can be reproduced accurately.

Second, there is a reduction in the ink the printer sprays. This increases precision and provides more control, which in turn improves picture quality—less ink sprayed means there is less liquid to smear the print. The thinner layer of ink dries faster, and this in turn means the ink doesn't spread from the point it was applied to. The increase in printing resolution means curves can be smoother, colour gradients can be better controlled, and greater detail can be brought out.

Another, different technology is thermal-dye technology, known as dye-sublimation printing. This is different from ink-based technology, and is suitable only for photo printing. A dye-sublimation printer has a long transparent sheet made up of the four colours—cyan,

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